SARAH NAHAR

Syracuse University

USING THE DOCTRINE OF DISCOVERY TO INCREASE SHARED LANGUAGE AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORKS BETWEEN BLACK AND INDIGENOUS FEMINIST ORGANIZING

Abstract

The majority of the interactions, historic and contemporary, between Black people and Indigenous Peoples living in the so-called United States occur(red) in the bloody context of settler colonial imperialism. In response to lived conditions, feminisms developed in various Black and Indigenous communities as part of resisting settler-colonialism, racism, sexism, capitalism and classism, and other forms of oppression. Feminist movements in Black and Indigenous communities have been proximate, overlapping, and mutually reinforcing, but also in tension with one another; competing at times, collaborative at others. Though both expansive areas of collective work, Black feminisms and Indigenous feminisms tend to center different aspects of the struggle for liberation. Some strain between movements comes from the inadvertent solidification of the settler state that can happen as some Black feminists struggle for their freedom and self-determination within the settler state without explicitly articulating an analysis of settler colonialism. Other tensions come from some Indigenous feminists' refusal of participation in solidarity politics in a way that weakens 'BIPOC' coalitions facing repression, and various expressions of uninterrogated antiblackness. This paper posits that the Doctrine of Discovery (DoD), a 15th century set of religious and state decrees that facilitated Christian European global exploration and expropriation, is a ripe site to analyze together for both Indigenous and Black feminist organizers because it allows for the incorporation of an analysis of settler colonialism without de-centering issues that are essential to Black feminist theory and practice. As a Black feminist organizer with some experience organizing alongside Indigenous feminists, in this paper I examine my own radical tradition regarding the absence of an articulated settler colonial analysis at two moments in US Black feminism--the Combahee River Collective statement of 1977 and the Allied Media Conference AfroFeministFutures panel in 2022. Then I return to how bringing in an analysis of the DoD can assist in increasing opportunities for generations of Black and Indigenous feminist organizers to express solidarity with each other through shared language and conceptual frameworks, for the purpose of healing our lineages, and practicing the liberatory politics we aspire to.

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"Asia, Africa, and Europe all meet in the Americas to labor over the dialectics of free and unfree, but what of the Americas themselves and the prior peoples upon whom that labor took place?"

– Jodi Byrd (2011)

[A prayer] that "we might come to know, love, and care for one another with deeper and more rigorous intimacy."

– brontë velez

Introduction

In the 1600s when enslaved Africans disembarked *en masse* and traveled weary to this *land mass*, they arrived in a place where hundreds of Indigenous groups lived since time immemorial.[1] The Africans were sold *as chattel* to European settlers who were actively advancing an imperial project that desired to produce wealth by extracting maximum profit through enslaved labor and maximum capital through land acquisition and elimination of Indigenous Peoples and exploitation of the ecosystems of Turtle Island.[2] As they extracted and eliminated, settlers replaced what was there with institutions that mimicked and maximized European life ways and epistemologies, creating a structure called settler colonialism. Black people were kidnapped, trafficked, enslaved, segregated, imprisoned, and assassinated by individuals and a system that did not value our personhood, but sought to exploit our bodies and souls.[3] It was into this situation that Harriet Tubman was born and lived a revolutionary life seeking to stop the exploitation and live free from bondage. This paper will come back to her leadership of the raid at Combahee River. The scenario in the 21st century is that Black people are tolerated but targeted, appropriated, and tokenized. The list of verbs chronicling

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[1] There are numerous timeframes in which to locate the beginning of settler-colonialism. Tarren Andrews, for example, dates it to the Medieval era. 1492 represents a particular type of rupture as well. I chose 1600 because of the sheer volume of "commerce" moving across the Atlantic in toxic triangles and quadrilaterals by this point in time. Furthermore, there are numerous ways to name both Indigenous connections to place while recognizing shared evolutionary history, without destabilizing Indigenous connections. Indigenous Peoples are connected to their homelands in an indissoluble, irreducible way, and in ways very different than European settler-colonists. I do not see this as a contradiction to the shared human evolutionary history of ancient migration of everyone from the Great Rift Valley in what is now called eastern Africa. People walked from there all over the world, and became some of the first humans to relate to all sorts of different lands and waters, to become indigenous to those places. As the timescales are vastly different (10,000 years ago vs. 1000 years ago), and "time immemorial" refers to "the time we collectively remember". Numerous indigenous groups on Turtle Island, for example, do not have a collective memory of the trek from Africa and their stories begin with them located en situ. Though the collective trek happened, sharing that information with Indigenous Peoples whose origin stories state otherwise should not be used to displace their claim of being aboriginal to their homelands, instead, only used to recognize the ultimate kinship among humans (homo sapiens) making all people deserving of mutual recognition as persons. Personhood, and relatedly, belonging through kinship or social circumstances, has not always been afforded to people of African descent, both within and outside of some Indigenous communities.

[2] The term Turtle Island is the Haudenosaunee and Anishinaabe (and others) name for the land also called North America that comes from their Creation stories. Though other groups have other names for all or other parts of this land mass, this term has now been widely adopted in broad-based indigenous movements for transformation and defense of the Earth. Furthermore, since I am writing this paper in Syracuse, New York (Onondaga Nation and seat of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy) I employ this term as it is what they use. May the writing of this paper be an honor to the past, present, and future members of the Confederacy.

[3] Kelly Hayes, "How to Talk about #NoDAPL: A Native Perspective," Truthout, October 28, 2016, https://truthout.org/articles/how-to-talk-about-nodapl-a-native-perspective/

indigenous oppression, though not identical to that of Black people, resonates. Indigenous peoples were (and continue to be) exploited, infected, schooled, silenced, relegated, and murdered by individuals and a system that did not (and does not) value their personhood, but sought (and seeks) to erase their bodies and souls.[4] In the 21st century, they also remain tolerated but targeted, appropriated, and tokenized.[5]

Though stories of legendary pre-colonial transatlantic exchanges between African peoples and indigenous Turtle Islanders exist, the interactions between most Africans and most Indigenous Peoples in the so-called modern era of the so-called United States (US) occurred in this context of imperialism, not an interaction of their own making. Bolstered by the Christian hegemonic discourse and actions (the Doctrine of Discovery) this context was anti-Black and anti-Native, as well as ecocidal.

The Origins of the Combahee River Collective Statement

50 miles from Charleston, South Carolina, is the mouth of the Combahee River, named for the Indigenous people of the place. It was home to numerous plantations where Black people were forced into the institution of slavery. Just after the Revolutionary war battles fought in the area, this fecund place supplied vast amounts of water for some of the new country's largest rice plantations, producing immense wealth for European-Americans (who now understood themselves to be white); returning none to the Indigenous Peoples, lands, and trafficked African laborers (now categorized as Black people) there. Indigenous and Black people repeatedly rebelled against the coercion, despite the punishing violence white people perpetuated upon them in order to maintain possession and build the US nation-state. Some of the early interactions between Black and Indigenous people happened in captivity in military forts--shared cells of incarceration for resistance to white possession of land, labor, and life.[6] It was at the Combahee River that Harriet Tubman led a Union Army regiment in a raid that destroyed millions of dollars of supplies going to the Confederate Army and freed over 750 enslaved Africans. This rebellion would be an inspiration to a quintessential Black feminist group over a century later, who named themselves the Combahee River Collective in honor of this history.

Black feminism is an ideology of Black women's (and those read as Black women) inherent worth and a practice of liberation of Black women and their communities from all oppression. It is a response to an anti-black, anti-female status quo. Through organizations, statements, political coalitions, and other forms of solidarity building and change-making, Black feminism confronts the interlocking systems of oppression of Black people (and others multiply oppressed and marked by the structures of white supremacist cisgendered heteropatriarchy) worldwide and offers an alternative vision for society. The common articulation of the movement traces its origin to resistance to enslavement and the particular ways that the institution impacted Black females. Regardless of their personal gender expression, they were gendered as women and experienced sexism. The sexual violence perpetrated against Black women in the context of the plantation and the impunity for white men, white women, and

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[4] Kelly Hayes, "How to Talk about #NoDAPL: A Native Perspective," Truthout, October 28, 2016, https://truthout.org/articles/how-to-talk-about-nodapl-a-native-perspective/.

[5] As an author who primarily identifies ethnically as a person of African descent, I will use personal or collective pronouns when speaking about Black people and our experience. Like many "African-Americans", I have ancestors who are "Native-Americans." That history and those connections were not kept alive in my immediate or extended families. Therefore, I employ the third person singular and plurals when referring to indigenous people and their experiences.

[6] Tiffany Lethabo King, with brontë velez, "On the Black Shoals: Part 2," For The Wild, December 14, 2022, https://forthewild.world/listen/tiffany-lethabo-king-on-the-black-shoals-316.

Black men who committed it created a devastating type of isolation. This dehumanization resulted in the articulation of a political framework that challenged the white feminist movement (in which racism existed), and the Black civil rights community (in which patriarchy existed), as well as broader society.[7]

The Combahee River Collective, as a specific Black feminist formation, lasted six years and was active in the Boston area from 1974-1980. In 1977, members Demita Frazier, Barbara and Beverly Smith, penned a statement that has become a central touchstone of the Black Feminist movement. Their self-description and reason for writing states:

We are a collective of Black feminists who have been...involved in the process of defining and clarifying our politics, while at the same time doing political work within our own group and in coalition with other progressive organizations and movements. The most general statement of our politics at the present time would be that we are actively committed to struggling against racial, sexual, heterosexual, and class oppression, and see as our particular task the development of integrated analysis and practice based upon the fact that the major systems of oppression are interlocking. The synthesis of these oppressions creates the conditions of our lives. As Black women we see Black feminism as the logical political movement to combat the manifold and simultaneous oppressions that all women of color face.[8]

The powerful statement of liberation was a strategic move to generate liberation. Combahee's legacy is taking decisive action to rupture society's operations to create space and safety for oneself and all oppressed others. As Harriet Tubman did this at Combahee in 1863, so they did as Black feminists in 1977.

Within the 4,000+ word statement, the writers focus on the genesis of contemporary Black feminism, their Collective's politics, beliefs, practices, issues, and the difficulties for Black feminists as they organize. The end of the introduction features the following paragraph: "We might use our position at the bottom, however, to make a clear leap into revolutionary action. If Black women were free, it would mean that everyone else would have to be free since our freedom would necessitate the destruction of all the systems of oppression."[9]

Throughout the next four decades Black feminist organizing has taken many forms as it combats "the manifold and simultaneous oppressions that women of color face."[10] It's intellectual contributions include Kimberlé Crenshaw's *Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex*[11] law review article which coined the term intersectionality, Pauli Murray's genius contributions to the world, Toni Cade Bambara and followers in the arts, Audre Lorde, bell hooks, Assata Shakur, the Spelman College Comparative Women's Studies program, and *many* more today.[12] The Black Lives Matter, and #MeToo movements are also powerful grassroots

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[7] In regards to the white feminist movement: while originally inspired by native women's powerful positions in their own communities and supported by coalition of abolitionists, ultimately the mainstream feminist movement chose to privilege its proximity to white supremacist patriarchy and disavowed and participated in the oppression of Indigenous, Black, and other people of color.

[8] Combahee River Collective, "The Combahee River Collective Statement," in Words of Fire: An Anthology of African American Feminist Thought, ed. Beverly Guy-Sheftall (New York: New Press, 1995), 231–40.

[9] Combahee River Collective, "The Combahee River Collective Statement," 233.

[10] Combahee River Collective, "The Combahee River Collective Statement".

[11] Kimberlé Crenshaw, "Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex: A Black Feminist Critique of Antidiscrimination Doctrine, Feminist Theory and Antiracist Politics," University of Chicago Legal Forum 1989, no. 1 (1989): 139–67, https://chicagounbound.uchicago.edu/uclf/vol1989/iss1/8.

[12] See www.blackwomenradicals.com for an ongoing web archive.

expressions of the leap into revolutionary action invited by Black feminism and the Combahee River Collective and their antecedents.

The writers did not explicitly address the settler colonial context in which they were writing, or in which Harriet was fighting. They wrote that they saw themselves at the bottom of society, as exploited Black female queer laborers. Critical Indigenous Studies scholar Jodi Byrd invites going a layer under the bottom. "But what of the Americas themselves and the prior peoples upon whom that labor took place?"[13] Byrd asks. This question is poignant because the liberal settler colonial nation-state is interested in shoring up its existence by finding ways to incorporate racialized populations to see their future within it. Many "diversity, equity, inclusion, and justice" efforts function to reify the state even while supposedly challenging it. Though for Black feminists the politics of representation has never been the main focus--rather the self-determination and wellbeing of our communities--the presence of the state and its functionaries was taken as a given. For Indigenous feminists, the theorizing against and beyond the settler colonial state itself, toward sovereignty and nationhood is key.[14] Using the imagery of perpetual cacophony that makes it difficult to orient oneself amidst noise, Byrd articulates the nation-states deflection and attention clouding:

As liberal multicultural settler colonialism attempts to flex the exceptions and exclusions that first constituted the United States to now provisionally include those people othered and abjected from the nation-state's origins, it instead creates a cacophony of moral claims that help to deflect progressive and transformative activism from dismantling the ongoing conditions of colonialism that continue to make the United States a desired state formation within which to be included.

That cacophony of competing struggles for hegemony within and outside institutions of power, no matter how those struggles might challenge the state through loci of race, class, gender, and sexuality, serves to misdirect and cloud attention from the underlying structures of settler colonialism that made the United States possible as oppressor in the first place. As a result, the cacophony produced through U.S. colonialism and imperialism domestically and abroad often coerces struggles for social justice for queers, racial minorities, and immigrants into complicity with settler colonialism. [15]

This treacherous reality is why it is important that even Black feminists explicitly articulate that settler colonialism is one of the interlocking systems of oppression. This elision in the Combahee River Collective statement leaves open the door for the US nation-state to co-opt Black feminism.

Allied Media Conference Panel: AfroFeministFutures

A generation later, in 2022, the AfroFeministFutures panel at the Allied Media Conference (AMC) drew on the Combahee River Collective's statement in order to theorize for the future.[16] As the opening panel to the most highly respected conference in young leftist activist circles, the selection of this topic reaffirmed how Black feminist principles and organizing are seen as the foundation for transformative possibilities and sharp analysis. All three of the Combahee

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[13] Jodi A. Byrd, The Transit of Empire: Indigenous Critiques of Colonialism (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2011), xxv.

[14] Bonita Lawrence and Enakshi Dua, "Decolonizing Antiracism," Social Justice 32, no. 4 (2005): 120–43, https://www.jstor.org/stable/29768340.

[15] Byrd, Transit of Empire, xvii.

[16] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures: For the World We Want," video, August 4, 2022, YouTube, 1:17:01, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iYM0Jf4mWjE.

River Collective statement writers are still alive. One, Demita Frazier, JD was on the panel and created an energizing linkage between eras. She was joined by Paris Hatcher of Black Feminist Futures, Emmanuelle 'Emani' Love of Wage Love Apothecary, Asha Ransby-Sporn of Chicago's Black Youth Project (BYP100) fame and Dissenters antimilitarism effort. The panel was moderated by Dr. Moya Bailey, author of *Misogynoir Transformed: Black Women's Digital Resistance* (2021).[17]

The panel began with a robust acknowledgement of the place of Detroit--the land (how it was stolen and the Indigenous people who call it home) and the waves of settlement by arrivants, immigrants, settlers, refugees, and their combinations.[18] [19] The acknowledgement also spoke of liberation practices that took place in Detroit, ostensibly to locate the AMC in this tradition. The first question asked the panelists which systems of oppression does the Black feminist work they do actively seek to destroy? The answers included combating:

- Policing, incarceration, and militarism (as the violent and armed part of the state that actively works to keep white supremacy, patriarchy, and capitalism/neoliberalism in place through violence or threats of violence)
- Individualism and perfectionism (cultural manifestations of heteropatriarchal white supremacy)
- Misogynoir and transmisogynoir (the particular type of intersectional hatred that Black women and Black trans folks face)
- Structural racism
- Homelessness
- Spiritual injustice (trauma inflicted by dominant Christian thinking).

Their answers reflected issues on which they specialize, even as they make common cause with broader movements. Other key points from the panel included:

- Recognizing that the Black community is actually multiple communities, not a monolith.
- Inviting non-Black allies to de-center themselves as they seek to be in solidarity
- Examining the risks involved in dismantling white supremacy
- Doing the very difficult healing of internalized inferiority within oneself
- Highlighting stories as the foundation for building political campaigns and understanding issues

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[17] The AfroFeministFutures panel at AMC focused on what these Black feminists are working on, and their thoughts about the future. There were parallels between it and the Indigenous Feminist Power Panel that occurred at the University of Saskatchewan in 2016. Both featured individuals who bring a feminist analysis to their work in whatever sector they are in. Both Black and Indigenous feminisms have become an area of academic and popular study, and the panels focused on the political organizing and direct action efforts that generated material for the emerging field to study. In both cases, scholarship in Indigenous and Black feminists reciprocally informs ongoing feminist political organizing. University of Saskatchewan, "Indigenous Feminisms Power Panel," video, March 28, 2016, YouTube, 1:12:21, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-HnEvaVXoto.

[18] Miles, Tiya. 2019. "Beyond a Boundary: Black Lives and the Settler-Native Divide." *The William and Mary Quarterly* 76 (3): 417–426. https://doi.org/10.5309/willmaryquar.76.3.0417.

[19] The question of language for non-white people who arrived at Turtle Island remains ambiguous and can either support ongoing erasure, or erroneously place Black people (enslaved or newly freed, depending on the time period) in the same category as European-American settler-colonists.

- Resisting tokenism and learning from the most marginalized
- Encouraging a shift away from state-centered solutions and activism, and shifting our relationships to one another in the process.

Destroying settler colonialism, or noting it as one of the interlocking systems of oppression did not happen in direct response to any question. The word decolonization was used only twice during the panel: once emphasizing the need to decolonize the spirit, and another time in reference to the mind. While critical thinking and spiritual agency are important, these uses do not refer to the return of land to indigenous people. Tuck and Wang, authors of "Decolonization is Not a Metaphor" have cautioned against using the word decolonization in North America when speaking about anything other than the distinct project of disordering the colonial world.[20] When used as metaphor, it often functions as signaling "both an awareness of the significance of Indigenous and decolonizing theorizations" but to include them in another struggle. This can downplay the incommensurability of efforts for recognition and/or sovereignty with those of civil and/or human rights struggles. Following Arvin et al., it is important to craft alliances that directly address differences.[21]

Developing greater shared language around what decolonization means is key. While in the North American context the phrase "decolonize your mind" is more problematic and leads to small education reforms, "decolonization of the mind" is a specific and important concern across Africa as folks are dealing with a "postcolonial" reality. In the Caribbean, it has been part of non-metaphorical consciousness-raising during anticolonial struggles and nation building efforts.[22]

The Beginning of an Analysis of Settler Colonialism Emerges at AMC 2022

Indigenous women from around Africa arrived at traditionally Native land bases that were often in turmoil. If the Indigenous nations of the place were able to escape genocidal attempts by European-Americans, they were being violently forced to relocate and under immense pressure to give up their sovereignty. The vast majority of Black women arrived enslaved (mostly laboring for whites and to a much less extent by Indigenous slavers); a structure that sought to strip them of their specific nation, culture, and heritage and force into a social position devoid of structural agency within the context of the settler colonial contestation--that is to make them "Black slaves." Black and Indigenous Feminist Futures Institute co-director Tiffany Lethabo King's work reminds that in the ferocious porosity of the earth-cum-plantation, the genocide that happened on the plantation grounds could be felt by the Indigenous Africans as they recalibrated to the new, tragic vibrations of the soil... and that this feeling "shaped their experience of enslavement and Blackness."[23] They knew land and agroecology well, and could tell the land was disturbed.

Early on in the panel, Frazier noted that Black feminism was "a movement for Black women's power that originated when we arrived on these shores."[24] Choosing to make the arrival of enslaved Africans to the US as the starting point for this struggle for power has consequences.

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[20] Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang, "Decolonization Is Not a Metaphor," Decolonization: Indigeneity, Education & Society 1, no. 1 (2012): 1–40.

[21] Maile Arvin, Eve Tuck, and Angie Morrill, "Decolonizing Feminism: Challenging Connections between Settler Colonialism and Heteropatriarchy," Feminist Formations 25, no. 1 (2013): 8–34, https://doi.org/10.1353/ff.2013.0006.

[22] David Naguib Pellow, personal interview, June 9, 2023.

[23] King, Tiffany Lethabo, with brontë velez. 2022a. "On the Black Shoals: Part 1." *For The Wild*, December 7. https://forthewild.world/listen/tiffany-lethabo-king-on-the-black-shoals-315.

[24] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

The first is that it elongates the timeframe in which US-based Black feminism is generally understood to exist. It is usually circumscribed as a "1970s onward" phenomenon that refined and built on and contested whitestream feminism's foundations. Frazier's main point seemed to be that Black feminism did not start with white women's experiences as its referent. The second consequence of Frazier's comment situates the beginning of the Black feminist movement directly in a nascent US settler colonial context.[25] Frazier was accessing the era before Black and Indigenous joint struggle against white possession and oppression was dispersed by colonial cacophony.[26] "We can reinvigorate [those moments] and reactivate them and bring them into a now..." King insists.[27] Frazier, initially winding up her answer about the challenges facing Black feminists and our allies, took an additional moment to talk about colonization, Indigenous positionality, and land directly. She shared a crucial piece of data that only she knew, but by conveying it created an AfroFeministFuture that was not possible before her articulation:

Back in the day when we, Barbara and Beverly and I, were trying to write the [Combahee River Collective] statement, there is something about the statement that 'if Black women are free, then everyone else will, of necessity, be free.' And I still don't feel 100% comfortable with that.

We are on land that was stolen and colonized and we struggle to make Indigenous women and the lives of Indigenous women at the center…and so I'm still trying to figure out how we braid those human experiences together so that when we talk about who's—what does freedom really mean and for whom—I think we have to begin more…we have to expand our vision on that.

But again I'm not going to go on and on." [someone from the audience far from the mic yells "go on!!" There is some laughter, and then rousing applause for Frazier's words][28]

With these words Frazier created an opening to discuss the concept of freedom in light of settler colonialism. What she meant by the half sentence "I think we have to begin more..." remains unclear. But the sentiment of the imperative for an expanded vision was one of the most poignant moments of the panel in terms of audience reaction and interaction from other panelists. As the enthusiastic applause died down, Ransby-Sporn began her comments, saying, "Wow, thanks for that. I want to talk more about that!" She pauses for an extended moment. However, her next comments spoke to the original question that was asked by moderator Bailey, as it related to Black women's freedom and centering those experiencing racial, gender, sexual, and class oppression.[29]

As often happens on panels, panelists' comments are influenced by what they hear others say. The multi-vocal design of a panel is already a disruption to the one-keynote speaker model. I wonder if the way Ransby-Sporn later speaks about the Combahee River Collective framework, as a framework of orienting to whomever is the most marginalized in a given situation, may be influenced by Frazier's comments. Either way it was a missed opportunity to speak further about the topic. Seeing their framework in this way, that it evolves over time,

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[25] Other origin points could be women's interventions in various forms of pre-modern African patriarchal systems, or Black women's contact with Phoenician, Chinese, or European explorers, or in one small nation's resistance to another nation's regional hegemony in Africa, for example.

[26] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[27] King, with velez, "On the Black Shoals: Part 2."

[28] After answering the question on the AMC panel, at 35:32 Frazier makes her additional remarks. Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[29] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

allows for greater openings for Black-Native revolutionary partnerships. Other than Frazier's comment, Indigenous women were not explicitly named again in the panel. Relationships to land were mentioned by Love with regards to rematriation (what is known to be an entire movement in some Indigenous communities), and the importance of holistic, loving, and regenerative relationships Black women could have with the land if we were free to do so. Love then moved back into metaphor, speaking about the "social remediation of our soul soil" (Allied Media Projects 2022).[30]

The work Black feminists have done and continue to do is tremendous. Yet there remains a key missing piece in both the Combahee River Collective and the AMC AfroFeministFutures panel: a robust analysis of settler colonialism. This elision replicates settler colonial erasure of indigenous peoples, their lives, and theorizations. Indigenous feminist theorizing was not completely invisible, but more than a land acknowledgment and more than a mention emerging between official questions is necessary to address the conditions we seek to ameliorate and the oppression we work to destroy. In addition to solidarity, the ability to articulate what's at stake for us as Black folks living in a settler colonial context is imperative for many reasons, the next section of this paper will discuss five.

Reasons to Integrate an Analysis of Settler Colonialism in Black Feminist Theory

Incorporating an analysis of settler colonialism in Black feminist theory will increase shared language and conceptual frameworks between it and Indigenous feminist theory. This sharing can create resonance powerful enough to cut through the colonial cacophony and help us, as Frazier articulated her desire, to braid our human experiences together. What follows are five reasons why I think this is important.

The first reason we must be able to articulate an analysis of settler colonialism is because Black feminists don't want to participate in harming other communities. Bell Hook's definition of love, which is a well-known animating force for Black feminism, is defined as "a combination of care, commitment, knowledge, responsibility, respect, and trust."[31] Hatcher brought that definition forth on the panel. Ransby-Sporn followed up saying that this love is incompatible with oppression. "The type of love we espouse requires accountability, reciprocity, consistency, and clarity. It is aligned and animates a radical politic and vision."[32] Settler colonialism, like slavery and racism, is a structure of the society, not an event in its history.[33] It is an ongoing harm, and its assumptions are embedded in all racist and sexist policies and extra-legal actions.[34] When our politics furthers the logic of elimination, however inadvertently, it becomes unloving, and requires accountability, un/learning, re/commitment, and change. Any refusal to take it seriously constitutes a move to innocence, which, even though we are not white people, reproduces the harm of settler colonialism associated with settler moves to innocence. [35]

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[30] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[31] hooks, bell. 2001. *All About Love: New Visions*. Harper Perennial.

[32] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[33] Patrick Wolfe, "Settler Colonialism and the Elimination of the Native," *Journal of Genocide Research* 8, no. 4 (2006): 387–409.

[34] Building on to Gilmore's definition of racism here, "Racism, specifically, is the state-sanctioned or extralegal production and exploitation of group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death." Ruth Wilson Gilmore, Golden Gulag: Prisons, Surplus, Crisis, and Opposition in Globalizing California (University of California Press, 2007).

[35] Tuck and Yang, "Decolonization Is Not a Metaphor," 1.

The second reason is that Black feminists have an invitation to acknowledge our positions within empire, however revealing and humbling this may be. It's an opportunity for self-reflective inquiry. Asking ourselves questions like, what does it mean to build wealth for ourselves and the Black community in a system based on white possession, Indigenous dispossession, and Black people *as* possessions? What does it mean to work for food sovereignty on stolen land? Critical Indigenous studies insists, in the words of Byrd, that

settler, native, and arrivant each *acknowledge* their own positions within empire and then *reconceptualize* space and history to *make visible* what imperialism and its resultant settler colonialisms and diasporas have sought to obscure. [36]

As a part of Indigenous critical theories, Indigenous feminist theories invite such *acknowledgment, reconceptualization,* and *visibilization* to happen in combination with an analysis of how the enduring impacts of patriarchy and other interlocking systemic oppressions refract the societal positions of each settler, native, and arrivant. Furthermore, Indigenous feminist theories value place-based and contextual analyses that result in practical positive impacts in the lives of Indigenous women, their communities, and nations. The imperative to address patriarchy and other interlocking systems of oppression makes Indigenous feminists ideal co-conspirators for Black feminists. Numerous collaborations are happening at this time, resulting in co-created art, deeply intersectional solidarity with Palestine, and co-published chapters such as the one by Robyn Maynard and Leanne Betasamosake Simpson entitled "Towards Black and Indigenous Futures on Turtle Island: A Conversation."[37] Responding to the invitation from other feminists through doing the hard work of developing shared language and a conceptual framework could bring us closer together.

We wouldn't be starting from zero. Tiffany Lethabo King, Cheryl Harris, and Tiya Miles, among others have written extensively. And as Frazier evidenced, even if a sentence of solidarity did not *explicitly* get in the Combahee River Collective statement there was a *desire* to also center Indigenous women's experiences—especially Indigenous feminist theorizing and activism. The discussion around what got included or not must have been intense as Frazier is still uncomfortable with its omission 45 years later. This desire got articulated explicitly in 2022, renewing the opportunity to build on it.

Third, there are women who are both Black and Indigenous. Challenging settler colonialism is a key part of their existence and resistance work, and since Black feminism cares about all oppressions that impact any Black women, settler colonialism should be very important to Black feminists. There are a number of content creators and movement leaders with this identity who are offering ideas and methods with regard to this, arising out of a variety of contexts, for example B. Anderson, Kailea Frederick, Sister Sadada Jackson, Shanya Cordis, Xhercis Méndez, Waltrina Middleton and more. Their intersectional leadership is important because it is not simply a matter of Black women ceding all central space to Indigenous women and only following. They bring together their identities in unique ways, have unique kinship networks, and their positionality as people who experience both settler-colonialism and racism

[36] It is from Byrd where I first encountered the poet Kamau Braithwaite's terms arrivant and arrivancy, and have since used it to gather people of the global majority living on Turtle Island for conversation about how we can do indigenous solidarity as peoples directly impacted by colonization. See bit.ly/AnticolonialArrivants for more information. Byrd, Transit of Empire. Byrd, Transit of Empire, xxx.

[37] Robyn Maynard and Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, "Towards Black and Indigenous Futures on Turtle Island: A Conversation," in Until We Are Free: Reflections on Black Lives Matter Canada, ed. Rodney Diverlus, Sandy Hudson, and Syrus Marcus Ware (Regina: University of Regina Press, 2020), 75–94, https://doi.org/10.1515/9780889776968-006.

in their life allow for a political orientation to imagine something like: Returning to Combahee together.

Fourth, shared language and analysis can assist in addressing ongoing antiblackness in Indigenous communities. Frazier noted in her comments that "many 19th century movements floundered due to racism, and really being able to see Black people as human equals remains a struggle today."[38] While Indigenous feminists generally have love and compassion for Black women and our communities, antiblack racism exists, even in activist spaces. I have experienced it personally. Furthermore, denial of the pervasive and global nature of antiblack racism as something that must be addressed in anticolonial structures has also created persistent tension between some activist groups. Language for Black people beyond the label settler is not solidified yet, but it can be quite painful when Indigenous people refer to all others as settlers. Learning the contours of another person or group's anguish can create spaces of empathy where deeper levels of one's own concerns can be shared. Given that "the building of a mass movement to leverage our powers will be an incredible challenge because most people are too conventional to appreciate feminist organizing,"[39] Black and Indigenous feminists can reduce isolation by co- developing a response to settler-colonialism that is complex enough to address both the manifestations of dispossession and antiblack racism that exist simultaneously in the contexts in which we organize. The LANDBACK Manifesto's language around the explicit connections between Black and Indigenous liberations addresses the dearth of addressing antiblackness in many other Indigenous and white settler anticolonial organizing spaces as well as sets a standard for other expressions of solidarity. [40]

Fifth, settler colonialism impacts Black women as well. In *The White Possessive,* Moreton-Robinson writes, "the question of how anyone came to be white or black in the United States is inextricably tied to the dispossession of the original owners and the assumption of white possession."[41] Because settler colonialism impacted Black people, we can integrate an analysis of settler colonialism while still maintaining the movement's integrity and a focus on the practical improvement of the lives of Black femmes and communities. Engaging the Doctrine of Discovery (DoD) can assist in this process because in addition to being the root of settler colonialism in the US and worldwide, this European colonial framework created the religious, legal, and mental justifications for invasion and slavery that negatively disrupted life on the continent of Africa.

Using the Doctrine of Discovery to Foreground an Analysis of Settler Colonialism

The Doctrine of Discovery (DoD, sometimes called the Doctrine of Christian Domination) is considered a major root of settler colonialism globally. The DoD is a set of 15th-century Catholic Papal Bulls that condoned the invasion, capture, murder, kidnapping and enslavement of anyone non-Christian.[42] Even before wreaking massive havoc on the peoples

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[38] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[39] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[40] In conversation with Dr. Danika Medak-Saltzman, she says, "core beliefs of most Indigenous communities historically make clear there is an understanding of the human family and our responsibilities to each other. Decolonizing ought to mean eliminating the influences of colonization which always already should mean eliminating antiblackness within and across native communities." LANDBACK, "LANDBACK Manifesto," n.d., accessed April 3, 2025, https://landback.org/manifesto/.

[41] Moreton-Robinson, Aileen. 2015. "Writing Off Treaties." In *The White Possessive: Property, Power, and Indigenous Sovereignty*, 84. University of Minnesota Press.

[42] A listing of these bulls includes *Papal Bull Dum Diversas* June 18, 1452; The Bull Romanus Pontifex (Nicholas V), January 8, 1454; and The Bull Inter Caetera (Alexander VI), May 4, 1493. Later expansions of these bulls include the Treaty of

and ecosystems of the so-called Americas, the Doctrine of Discovery justified the Christian conquest over and mistreatment of Muslims (Saracens) and invasion of the lands of African peoples (pagans) and all of their lands. African countries and communities continue to suffer due to colonization and imperialism. And this set of religious documents that made their way into so-called secular legal frameworks in the US and elsewhere govern the lives of millions of Black people. There isn't an area of life untouched by the DoD. It influences the legal, carceral, educational, health care, and economic system, to name a few of the interlocking systems of oppressions it legitimizes.

The oft cited paragraph from 1452 *Dum Diversas* instructs Christian explorers on what to do if they found land where no European Christians were living. They were to

> ...invade, search out, capture, vanquish, and subdue all Saracens and pagans whatsoever, and other enemies of Christ wheresoever placed, and the kingdoms, dukedoms, principalities, dominions, possessions, and all movable and immovable goods whatsoever held and possessed by them and to reduce their persons to perpetual slavery.[43]

In the US the DoD's codification into law occurred in 1823 when the Supreme Courts enshrined it through its decision of Johnson v M'Intosh making the government the only eligible sellers of Native land title. Even earlier, in the 1790-1793 writings of Thomas Jefferson, the DoD was used as justification for claiming the Pacific Northwest, as well as negotiating with France and Spain around the massive purchase of land from them (without regard for Native sovereignty and life in those areas).[44] As recently as 2005 the DoD was cited by the Supreme Court, and the DoD itself has not been repudiated by the Catholic Church. Numerous Indigenous activists and their allies have been working in disparate locations and institutions (ecclesial and otherwise) to try to build a movement to dismantle the DoD. The budding movement holds conferences and does base-building activities. It is gaining momentum and envisages itself mobilizing a broad base. It is a space for Black feminists to learn and contribute as the discourse will be greatly enhanced by the participation of a critical number of Black feminists.

The first DoD decree issued in 1452 enabled Portuguese sailors to invade the homes and lands of Indigenous Peoples in west Africa: to plunder their relations, to kidnap and enslave them. Until forcibly baptized, Africans were not seen as human, and therefore the land was considered empty of humans (*terra nullius*), and available for "resource extraction" by the Portuguese crown. As Portugal lost power, other European nations justified by the power of the DoD laid claim to the same lands (and more!) of Indigenous Africans, possessing it and all "moveable and immovable goods." Indigenous Africans, like Indigenous Peoples in the so-called Americas, were considered moveable goods and real estate. Slavery became an economic engine, moving these "goods and real estate" across the Atlantic.

Tordesillas, June 7, 1494; the Patent Granted by King Henry VII to John Cabot and his Sons, March 5, 1496; The Requerimiento, 1514. Doctrine of Discovery Project, "Doctrine of Discovery Project."

[43] Nicholas V, *Dum Diversas*, Papal Bull, June 18, 1452, https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/.

[44] The "foundational US Indian policy as stated in 1783 by General (and later President) George Washington was the 'Savage as the Wolf.' As he explained to Congress, the expectation of the United States was that Indian lands and resources would naturally be acquired by Americans. Washington compared Indians to animals that would naturally retreat and lose their lands to the advance of the United States. The US government operated under this policy until the 1960s." Robert J. Miller, Jacinta Ruru, Larissa Behrendt, and Tracey Lindberg, *Discovering Indigenous Lands: The Doctrine of Discovery in the English Colonies* (Oxford University Press, 2010).

While slavery takes up significant space in our imaginary as African diasporic peoples living in the US, recognizing the harm settler colonialism, via the DoD, caused to us *as* indigenous peoples can help us get back in touch with our own indigeneity and sense of land connection. However distant in the past, it did exist. Whether or not we remember the land skills of our ancestors, King maintains that wherever we are, "the land is making space for you. It remembers you. It is calling you and pulling you towards it."[45] Our communities lived in ways that were reciprocal, regenerative, and relational with the environments they had known for thousands of years. The wound of being torn from those is incalculable. Whether or not our indigeneity was fully eliminated in this process remains an open and heartbreaking question. In addition to the violence of separation from one's sovereign home, plantation slavery in Brazil, the Caribbean, and the US extracted labor from Black bodies as part of projects of extraction from the Earth. This caused trauma to both entities and forged a traumatic relationship between them. Gesturing back to and extending Emani Love's comment on the panel, healing Black relationship to land is rebellion against settler colonial racial capitalism which sought to break it.

The ability of police to kill with near total impunity *both* Black and Indigenous people today is evidence of the DoD, as is the violent state repression when either community mobilizes for self-determination. The DoD document *Requerimiento* reveals the blueprint. It was read to peoples whose lands were being encountered by the Spanish for the first time. If an Indigenous community did not willingly surrender their land, liberty, and lifeways, and convert to European Christianity, the following would happen:

We will take you and your wives and children and make them slaves, and as such we will sell them, and will dispose of you and them as Their Highnesses order. And we will take your property and will do to you all the harm and evil we can, as is done to vassals who will not obey their lord or who do not wish to accept him, or who resist and defy him. We avow that the deaths and harm which you will receive thereby *will be your own blame,* and not that of Their Highnesses, nor ours, nor of the gentlemen who come with us.[46]

This sentiment is echoed in 'Virginia Slave Codes' two centuries later, which both racially codified slavery and permitted violence against racialized people:

All servants imported and brought into the Country...who were not Christians in their native Country...shall be accounted and be slaves. All Negro, mulatto and Indian slaves within this dominion... shall be held to be real estate. If any slave resist his master... correcting such slave, and shall happen to be killed in such correction...the master shall be free of all punishment...as if such accident never happened.[47]

These documents form the basis of the US legal system, law enforcement, segregation, and gentrification--they are rooted in the past and ongoing systems of oppression. The frameworks for punishment for resistance, baked-in impunity for law enforcement, and the entire prison system is built on the supremacies generated by the DoD. Note the italics above as to lack of culpability for the Europeans. Locating the fight to defund the police in a settler colonial, as well as race-based, framework allows for a deeper analysis than racial hatred to understand why the system is so entrenched, and what strategies will be required to abolish it. There is a

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[45] King, with velez, "On the Black Shoals: Part 2."

[46] Doctrine of Discovery Project, "Doctrine of Discovery Project," n.d., accessed April 3, 2025, https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/.

[47] Beloved Community Initiative, "Doctrine of Discovery," n.d., Beloved Community, Asheville, NC, accessed April 3, 2025, https://becomingbelovedcommunity.org/doctrine-of-discovery.

growing body of literature on police and prison abolition. Lots of exciting opportunities—due to terrifying conditions—for Black and Indigenous feminists and carceral abolitionists to connect to produce knowledge together. One such example of this is the new book (May 2023 release date) by Kelly Hayes and Miriam Kaba, called *Let This Radicalize You: Organizing and the Revolution of Reciprocal Care*.[48] I am looking forward to see how the DoD is addressed, if at all.

The Slave Codes later morph into Black Codes that go into effect after emancipation. These Codes control the movement of Black people and create a police state to monitor Black conduct and punish any form of "deviance." This leads to segregation, which further solidifies white society's self-referentiality and supremacy thinking due to separation and spatial power (in rural and urban spaces). In the last century this meant redlining, divestment, and programs such as urban renewal. In the contemporary era this means gentrification. The connection back from gentrification to the DoD is that the DoD is a document of entitlement to claim any place they want to live, and go live there. Still today many white people feel they are entitled to live anywhere they want, claiming it for themselves and, often, changing the historic character of the space (be it a continent, country, or neighborhood). Like the European Christian explorers before them they see themselves as "improving and investing" while ignoring or repressing the resistance from residents along the way.

The DoD is a legal, cultural, and economic framework that came from a particular religious tradition. Religion (defined as a set of stories, orientations, rituals, and meaning making activities) is visible in the DoD. Therefore, it's a vital and often overlooked site of analysis that is necessary to include in and analyze as any part of a genealogy of white supremacy. Furthermore, race, as a social construction co-developed with modern Christian religious thinking, which also co-developed with colonialism. Paul Kivel, Jewish anti-violence educator, author, and activist writes:

Researching the history of racism led me to understand that before Europeans understood themselves to be white they thought of themselves as Christian. Jews, Pagans and Muslims were the long-standing Others. When encountered, [Indigenous Peoples] and Africans became new heathens in the same good/evil equation. It was only when some Jews and Muslims, and subsequently [Indigenous Peoples] and enslaved Africans, began to convert to Christianity that white Christians felt the need to draw an uncrossable line. Even if members of these groups became Christian, they would still be ineligible for participation in society because they were not white. Being a white Christian (and a cishet man) became the criterion for being fully human.[49]

Since many Black folks have experience with the Christian church, understanding this historical background offers an opportunity to interrogate various religious inheritances. It is important to interrogate what aspects of Christianity, mediated through white supremacy, have influenced the ways Black Christians understand themselves, their theology and ethics. Some of the things considered essential to the faith have little to do with its indigenous wisdom tradition orientations in the ancient near east, and more to do with European interpretations of the previously pacifist and communal faith practices. A few examples include negative views of the naked body, constructions of masculinity and femininity, dance, and the nuclear family structure.

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[48] Kelly Hayes and Mariame Kaba, Let This Radicalize You: Organizing and the Revolution of Reciprocal Care (Haymarket Books, 2023).

[49] Paul Kivel, Living in the Shadow of the Cross: Understanding and Resisting the Power and Privilege of Christian Hegemony (New Society Publishers, 2013).

Though there were continental Africans who were Christian before being trafficked and enslaved, most Black folks encountered the Christian church in the context of enslavement. It was generally used by white Christians in an attempt to pacify enslaved peoples. Upon reading the Biblical text, however, many connected to the stories of liberation therein. Most of the biblical stories are codified oral traditions from other indigenous groups. Issues of slavery, proto-settler colonialism, conquest, and other themes appear in the compilation of texts considered "Holy Scriptures" by many. For Black feminists involved in organizing communities of faith, there is an opening here to de-westernize Christianity and re-situate the Bible as a product of the northern African and eastern Mediterranean geopolitical and cultural contexts.

There are more reasons to use the DoD as a way to integrate an analysis of settler colonialism into Black feminism. They will emerge once Black feminists begin to wrestle with the DoD and its implications. Since Black feminism is grounded in practical action, integrating the analysis of settler colonialism will lead to actions informed by it.

Making Common Cause: Imagining Shared Futures

Creating spaces like that of the AMC AfroFeministFutures panel will allow Black feminists to reflect on the legacy of Black feminism, and what futures can look like. They are a place to practice articulating a Black feminist analysis of settler colonialism as one of the interlocking systems of oppression. No doubt in the future other oppressions will be explicitly added to the list of race, class, gender, and sexuality. These panels are also spaces to reflect on how the liberal multicultural settler state is trying to entice us. As we expand our vision to unapologetically and enthusiastically also center indigenous women and land we actualize Frazier's vision of braiding our human experiences together as Black and Indigenous feminists. Frazier here uses the image of braiding as a metaphor, but it is also a material fact and practice that is precious to both Black and Indigenous cultures. Braiding each other's hair or other organic material are key sites of knowledge sharing, laughter, and affirmation between women, girls, grandmothers, etc.

Building on Frazier, Ransby-Sporn interpreted the Combahee River Collective's statement "if Black woman were free…" not as one that narrows the scope of "what freedom means and for whom", but as a framework that points us towards putting our attention on the margins.[50] For her, the Collective's statement was about the undoing of state violence, revolution and transformation, *from the margins*. Since the people writing the statement, Black queer socialist feminists, were highly marginalized at the time of writing, the statement is about *whomever* is at the margins, making sure they are centered in the discourse and political struggle. Examining who's at the margins "is not a one-time event…it's an ongoing process that we have to always be engaged in. [What Combahee gave us] is a vision of collective freedom for all of us."[51] Since "the logics of white possession and the disavowal of Indigenous sovereignty are materially and discursively linked" Black and Indigenous feminists can leverage their distinct yet connected positionalities to create a nuanced analysis with shared language and conceptual frameworks and offer it to broader activist movements for collective freedom.[52]

This work is necessary as the state becomes simultaneously more violent and more diffuse, offering green capitalist techno-solutions to the climate crisis of its own making (while the

[50] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[51] Allied Media Projects, "AfroFeministFutures."

[52] Moreton-Robinson, "Writing Off Treaties."

poor, Black, Indigenous, and other people bare the disproportionate burden of the crisis others created in attempts to endlessly benefit themselves at the expense of everyone and everything else). What leaps into revolutionary action will emerge from this generation of Indigenous and Black feminists being in rigorous conversation with one another? There are other methods in addition to using the DoD that have created generative relationships and have nurtured Black and Indigenous feminist collaborations.[53] These include creating ceremonial spaces and remembering joint projects of rebellion, enjoying sacred laughter and honoring grief in the process of creating rituals, sharing stories, and conversing together. Academic, activist, spiritualist, and internet-media savvy communication approaches are all important for building the friendships of understanding and embodied solidarity that we need for our collective future.

Return to Combahee

Though the Collective members never went to the site of the Combahee River raid together, the place itself would be a significant one to re-Source the Black feminist and Indigenous feminist movements and help us to relate to one another as relatives.[54] A return to Combahee in 2027, the 50th anniversary of its writing, provides an opportunity to bring the people working on these multiple approaches together. As an exercise in futurity, I conclude with a visualization.

Envision a group of Black feminists gathered along the Combahee River near the Santee Delta recreation area. They have invited Indigenous feminists to accompany them to this place for a ceremony of renewing the influential Black feminist statement for this generation. Everyone is flush(ed) with excitement to meet one another and curious how our entangled pasts might lead to shared, collaborative, intentional futures. In preparation for the moment, words from the original statement have changed, shifted, been removed, and added: words such as "free, bottom, isolation, revolutionary, and all systems of oppression" have taken on new intensity and depth as an analysis of settler colonialism refracts them. The group of Black and Indigenous feminists who did the (re)writing are celebrated, since words create worlds. Bellies full of tasty food prepared lovingly, the gathered crowd remains hungry for this world we are creating anew.

It is April, and most of the group traveled to the drenched soil mouth of the river by way of Charleston. The tears on their cheeks barely dry from their streaming during a visit to Emmanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church, a site where white supremacist settler colonial death struck unapologetically in 2015. The murderous act of business as usual that day created cruel reverberations across time and space that can be felt in our bodies. The crowd is determined to dance harder because of it, and the vibrations and ululations fill the sky as a murmuration makes its way north. Some people arrive later, and make their way toward the sacred fire, stopping periodically to bring up pictures of their babies on the phone. A full carload of others in active conversation pull into the public parking area and hop out of the car asking, "how do Indigenous and Black feminist solidarities build? What are the impediments to this collective building?" They know the answers will require them to remember who they are "outside of oppressors' institutions, ideologies, and imaginations."[55]

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[53] King, with velez, "On the Black Shoals: Part 1."

[54] In the Indigenous Feminist Power Panel, Kim TallBear expressed an interest in relating to Black leaders in a people to people way, not mediated by white supremacy.

[55] Amber Starks, "Envisioning Black Liberation and Indigenous Sovereignty," September 22, 2021, https://usdac.us/news/2021/9/21/envisioning-black-liberation-and-indigenous-sovereignty.

Being in the same space together certainly helps, everyone agrees and hustles to the designated spot.

Before any statement is spoken or dances are danced, the river itself is honored. Gifts placed along the loamy banks. The Combahee, Kusso, and Yamasee people are centered, and as many stories of the place as people wish to share, are shared. Layer upon layer is added, and stories connected to those stories are told. In the air there is a sense of plenty of time *and* a sense of spiritual urgency. The place of Combahee receives the stories about it and reflects back its glorious centrality to the story of liberation from slavery, of teamwork and strategy, of choice, of Harriet Tubman, of community nourishment. Tiffany Lethabo King's refrain "I trust Black freedom dreams when they consider Native freedom" is repeated throughout King with velez.[56] There is also time for silence, through which we encounter each other on our own (beyond English) terms. Time enough to wipe the dust of colonial cacophony from our ears in order to hear our original sounds.

Bats, mycelium, and stars observe. B. Anderson, Kailea Frederick, Alexis Pauline Gumbs, Assata Dela Cruz, Shanya Cordis, Xhercis Méndez, Waltrina Middleton, Amber Starks (aka Melanin Mvskoke), Tao Leigh Goffe and their team from darklaboratory.com make offerings. As they do, the group intones with them. Some people are braiding hair, others braiding grasses. After the festivities, everyone returns from where they came, rearranged on the molecular level by the encounter. Copies of the reworked Combahee River Collective statement, written on tiny pocket scrolls are passed out as souvenirs--phylacteries we carry and can touch as we cross thresholds, sharing the message with our children of spirit and blood--prayers for a sovereign shared future and free spirits. We depart with the hope that in another 50 years, a generation will return to reflect and rework our words, as the world-making continues.

[56] This paper is a work of mutual co-arising. As I was about to turn it in as a final paper for Indigenous Feminist Theory and Thought class, on December 15, 2022, I For The Wild on Instagram just became available to the public. So exciting! I noticed that their resource lists do not cite Combahee or the AMC panel. I have since reached out to brontë share this vision of what a confluence of these streams of Black feminism may look like...how she and I might work together to actualize a vision of 2027. King, with velez, "On the Black Shoals: Part 2."